a much briefer paper, suitable for appearance in some chemical journal—if they were willing to accept it. This meant periodic sessions with Dawson, as in the previous year, and I was slowly finishing it.

I was also drawing toward the end of "—And Now You Don't."

Then, too, I received a request, at about this time, for a story for a

new science-fiction anthology. Oddly enough, I was asked to pick the

story myself and to give a reason for my choice. There was only one

catch: I must not pick a story from Astounding because they could not

clear permissions from that magazine. That put me in a bind, since my best stories had all appeared in Astounding.

I chose "Robot AL-76 Goes Astray" and in giving my reason for the choice carefully refrained from saying it was any good (which it wasn't). I simply said it was my humorous robot story and I had picked it for its lightheartedness.

I made my Introduction lighthearted, too. In fact, as I reread that Introduction now, I see in it a considerable bit of that style that was to become common for me at later times—a mixture of self-denigration and self-esteem in equal quantities. I said at one point:

"In a sense, it's a self-satire. Of course, it's a great day for an author when he becomes important enough to be satirized, and if I waited for a spontaneous gesture on the part of others, I could wait decades—centuries, if I lived long enough."

It earned me $30, but when the anthology finally appeared, later in the year, it turned out to be money ill-got. It was entitled My Best Science-fiction Story, the subtitle being As Selected by 25 Outstanding Authors. I didn't mind being an outstanding author but, my goodness, "Robot AL-76 Goes Astray" was not my best science-fiction story and I never said it was. I chafed quite a bit at that.

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I received a nice letter from Lyle Boyd, inviting me to dinner on February 9, so I took the Yankee Clipper from Grand Central Station at 1 :oo p.m. and had